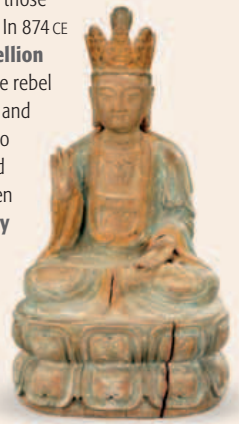


As ambitious officials jostled for power, the Tang dynasty was severely weakened.

THE LATE TANG

After the fall of Xuanzong, successive emperors tried to **revive China's fortunes**, but to no avail. Powerful families evaded tax and the burden fell increasingly on those who were less able to pay. In 874 CE a significant **peasant rebellion** broke out. Huang Chao, the rebel leader, captured Chang'an and forced **Emperor Xizong** to flee. The emperor returned once the rebellion had been quashed, but his **authority had collapsed**. Military governors seized power, and in 907 CE the Tang dynasty was overthrown.



BUDDHIST STATUE

SUPPRESSION OF BUDDHISM

The increasing wealth and influence of Buddhism led to a **growing campaign of criticism** headed by Confucian scholars in the early 9th century. Anti-Buddhist feeling within the government reached its height in 845 CE, when **Emperor Wuzong** ordered the **destruction** of 4,600 **Buddhist monasteries** and the surrender of their lands to the state; 250,000 monks were secularized and thrown back into society, and Buddhism never regained its influence in China.



the world's largest city. Covering more than 30 square miles (77 km²), more than one million people lived inside its walls, and another million beyond them. Linked by a network of roads and canals to the rest of the empire, Chang'an was the terminus of the Silk Road (see pp.184–85), and traders from across Asia came to its great markets. Horses, essential for fighting against the nomadic tribes to the north and east, were imported from the Tarim Basin, and glass goblets came from Byzantium (see pp.198–99). Silk, ceramics, brick tea, and papers were traded in exchange. Foreign cultures were welcomed, and within the city walls were Daoist temples, Buddhist monasteries, Zoroastrian shrines, and Islamic mosques.



Three-glaze figurine
Developed in the 7th century, *sancai* (three-color) glaze, was widely used on vessels and figurines and is typical of the Tang dynasty. Its colors were green, amber, and cream.

levels of sophistication. Two of China's greatest poets flourished in this period: Li Bai and Du Fu, known respectively as the Poet Immortal and the Sage Poet. Li Bai cultivated a reputation for eccentricity; many of his poems celebrate the joys of wine and women.

The poems of Du Fu, by contrast, dealt with more serious moral and historical issues. Landscape painting evolved under the poet artist Wang Wei, who painted evocative winter scenes, and Wu Daozi developed a Chinese style of Buddhist sculpture. The court painter Han Gan was best known for his depictions of horses, a subject that continued to inspire artists in later periods.

The decline of the Tang

In the 730s CE Xuanzong's control over his government began to slip. A number of aristocrats began to displace the career officials. The most notorious of these was Li

Linfu, who by 752 CE had made himself virtually a dictator. The emperor, who was 72 years old by this time, had ceased to play an active role in government.

He had become infatuated with Yang Guifei, who was his son's concubine and a famous beauty. After Xuanzong made her imperial consort, she persuaded him to promote her cousin Yang Guozhang to a senior position at court; when Li Linfu died, Yang took his place.

Among the professional soldiers who had been given commands along the frontier was an officer named An Lushan. He became a favorite (and possibly a lover) of Yang Guifei. The

rivalry between An Lushan and Yang Guozhang at court led the former to raise a rebellion in 755 CE. The emperor was forced to flee from Chang'an. His military escort demanded the execution of Yang Guifei, blaming her for the emperor's misfortunes, and Xuanzong had no option but to accept. Though An Lushan was eventually defeated and the rebellion brought to an end, the Tang dynasty never recovered its former strength and glory.

INVENTION

PRINTING

The *Diamond Sutra*, the oldest surviving example of a printed book, was found in a walled-up chapel at Dunhuang on the Silk Road. With an inscription dated 868 CE, it predates the earliest European book, the Gutenberg Bible (see pp.256–57), by over 500 years. Seven strips of yellow-stained paper printed from carved wooden blocks are pasted together to form a scroll over 13 ft (4 m) long. It is one of the most important works of the Buddhist faith. It was called the *Diamond Sutra* because "its teaching will cut like a diamond blade through worldly illusion."



Flowering of the arts

Xuanzong was a great patron of the arts, and during his reign Chinese painting and literature reached new